

the fragility in the Indian ranks. A heavy burden was placed on him, while his support cast of bowlers did not exactly set the charts on fire. To be fair, Mohammed Siraj did his best and had 20 scalps to show, while Akash Deep exuded promise.

And in a tussle in which spin was deemed an afterthought, R. Ashwin retired midway, nursing a massive legacy while leaving a huge vacuum. But if a cold appraisal is done, India lost because its batters failed. Yashasvi Jaiswal, K.L. Rahul, Rishabh Pant and Nitish Kumar Reddy had their moments; so did the lower order of Ravindra Jadeja, Sundar, Bumrah, and Akash, but as a collective, the willow wielders became paper boats, soaked and washed away in a downpour.

Kohli had a ton in Perth and subsequently dallied around the off-stump and retreated. Skipper Rohit Sharma missed Perth due to a paternity break, and once he linked up with the squad, he lost his mojo. His batting horrors were so stark (31 runs from five outings) that he opted out in Sydney. It was a piece of information badly handled in the way it was hinted to the world. Never ideal for a team with its back to the wall and trailing 1-2 ahead of the climax.

Usually once past the deep seas, India would lose the opening Test and keep scrambling before finding a semblance of form towards the end. This time around, the reverse



IF BUMRAH WAS LIGHT AND PATHWAYS, HOPE AND MAGIC, HE ALSO IN AN OBLIQUE WAY REVEALED THE FRAGILITY IN THE INDIAN RANKS



happened. The performance in Perth was terrific, and it seemed as if the Aussies were in disarray, and an innocuous line by Josh Hazlewood

